Asta

Swiatek 1995 Gifted Adolescents' Coping Strategies and Peer Acceptance

Table of Contents

Background on social coping strategies in gifted adolescents

Core coping strategies identified by Swiatek (1995)

Peer acceptance, popularity, and conformity dynamics

Measurement and structure of Swiatek's coping framework

Consequences and broader patterns of denying or hiding giftedness

Background on social coping strategies in gifted adolescents

Gifted adolescents can face social stress because being seen as "gifted" may bring stigma from peers. Social coping strategies arise as ways to manage this risk and protect belonging, status, and day-to-day peer relations. (1 source)

A useful starting point for Swiatek's work is the broader finding that some gifted youth do not simply enjoy the label of giftedness; they can also experience social costs from it. Later scholarship summarizing this area notes that gifted children may face social stigmatization tied to being labeled gifted, alongside other pressures such as perfectionism and heightened sensitivity. This helps explain why coping strategies become important in adolescence, when peer approval and fitting in often matter more: strategies such as hiding, downplaying, or otherwise managing visible signs of high ability can be understood as responses to the risk of being set apart socially. (Guthrie, 2019)

Evidence

(Guthrie, 2019)

"Nothing is ever easy": Parent Perceptions of Intensity in Their Gifted Adolescent Children

> *"For example, some gifted children experience social stigmatization from being labeled gifted (Coleman, 1985;Neihart, 2002; (Swiatek, 1998), unhealthy perfectionism (Christopher et al., 2010)(Silverman, 2007), and hyper-sensitivities or intensities (Dabrowski, 1964;Daniels & Piechowski, 2009a; see Mendaglio & Tillier, 2006)."*

Core coping strategies identified by Swiatek (1995)

Swiatek's framework describes several ways gifted adolescents try to manage peer risk. The most common patterns are denying giftedness, trying to be more popular, and conforming so high ability is less socially visible. (3 sources)

- **Denying giftedness:** Gifted adolescents may deny their abilities outright or downplay what those abilities mean in social life. The point is often to avoid standing out and to make peer acceptance easier. (Laznibatova et al., 2018) (Tourreix et al., 2023)
- **Trying to increase popularity:** Another strategy is to work on being seen as likable, socially active, or broadly accepted, so giftedness carries less social cost. This fits Swiatek's idea that some adolescents try to reduce the effect of giftedness on peer acceptance by building status in other ways. (Laznibatova et al., 2018) (Tourreix et al., 2023)
- **Conformity:** Adolescents may act more like their peer group, including hiding giftedness or matching peer

behavior, so they do not appear too different. In this sense, conformity is a way to make giftedness less visible in daily social settings. (Laznibatova et al., 2018) (Tourreix et al., 2023)

- **Minimizing the visibility of giftedness:** Related to denial and conformity, some students use broader impression-management moves to keep high ability from being too obvious. This can include reducing visible signs of giftedness in social settings. (Peairs et al., 2011)
- **Using socially accepted compensatory activities:** Some gifted adolescents increase involvement in activities that peers value, which can help balance or offset the social meaning of being seen as highly able. (Peairs et al., 2011)
- **Denying concern about rejection:** Another coping move is to claim not to care about possible social rejection or popularity. Tourreix et al. describe this as denying the importance of popularity, while Peairs et al. frame it as denying concern about rejection. (Tourreix et al., 2023) (Peairs et al., 2011)
- **Other strategies named in later summaries of Swiatek's framework:** Later reviews also group in tactics such as using humor, helping others, and staying highly engaged in social activity to share common interests and keep busy with peers. These expand the picture beyond simple hiding, showing that coping can also involve active social connection. (Tourreix et al., 2023)

Paper	Coping Strategies	Comparison Group	Non-Cognitive Specificities	Social Influence	Psychological Impact	Environmental Context
Coping Strategies of Intellectually Gifted and Common Adolescents Attending Grammar School in the Context of the Personality Dimensions Structure	Social isolation, social support (less used), problem solving, escape into fantasy, self-criticism.	Common adolescents attending grammar schools in Bratislava.	Gifted adolescents use social isolation more; less social support; personality traits influence strategy choice.	Gifted pupils use social isolation more, less social support strategy.	Gifted pupils experience more social isolation, less social support.	Grammar school setting in Bratislava, comparison with common intellect peers.
Academic Giftedness and Alcohol Use in Early Adolescence	Experimenting with alcohol as compensation for social price.	Nongifted peers, nongifted adolescents who tried alcohol, gifted and nongifted abstainers.	High desirability of social acceptance; distancing from "gifted" image.	Experimenting with alcohol compensates for social price of academic talents.	Trying alcohol associated with negative adjustment, giftedness moderates risk.	Peer context that promotes substance use, risk for adjustment difficulties.

Evidence

(Laznibatova et al., 2018)

Coping Strategies of Intellectually Gifted and Common Adolescents Attending Grammar School in the Context of the Personality

Dimensions Structure

> *"Swiatek (1995) introduced the concept of social coping strategies in gifted adolescents. She identified six social coping strategies, of which the first three – denying giftedness, trying to increase popularity and conformity have proved to be the most common. Gifted adolescents often deny their abilities or at least downplay their meaning to gain peer acceptance."*

(Tourreix et al., 2023)

Non-Cognitive Specificities of Intellectually Gifted Children and Adolescents: A Systematic Review of the Literature

> *"There appear to be coping strategies that are specific to giftedness (Swiatek, 1995)(Swiatek, 2001), such as denying giftedness; reducing the impact of giftedness on peer acceptance; hiding giftedness or conforming to peers' behaviors; denying importance of popularity; using humor; helping others; and engaging in social interactions and a high activity level to keep busy and share common interests."*

(Peairs et al., 2011)

Academic Giftedness and Alcohol Use in Early Adolescence

> *"In fact, researchers have identified that gifted adolescents often engage in various social coping strategies to minimize the visibility of their giftedness, including denial of their giftedness, minimizing the visibility of giftedness, increased involvement in socially acceptable compensatory activities, and denying concern about possible social rejection (see, e.g., (Cross et al., 1991)Swiatek, 1995)."*

Peer acceptance, popularity, and conformity dynamics

In Swiatek's line of work, peer acceptance is a key reason some gifted adolescents hide or soften signs of giftedness. Popularity and conformity can work as social tools: they help students fit in, but they can also create pressure to act less able than they are. (6 sources)

A central idea in this literature is that coping is not just about ability; it is about managing social belonging. Later summaries of Swiatek's framework state this very directly: to gain peer acceptance, gifted adolescents may deny giftedness, put more value on popularity, and conform to peer norms. (Korolov, 2024) This link between acceptance and coping also appears in newer reviews, which note that popularity and peer acceptance among gifted students have been tied to denial of giftedness and conformity to peers. (Pinxten et al., 2026)

This dynamic matters in part because some gifted adolescents see themselves as less popular or more socially at risk than other students. Work summarized by Yun et al. reports that highly gifted adolescents have been found to perceive themselves as less popular and to have more social and emotional problems than average adolescents, while modestly gifted adolescents were rated higher than highly gifted peers in popularity and social standing. That pattern suggests that being more visibly gifted can carry peer-relation costs, which helps explain why popularity becomes a coping issue in the first place. (Yun et al., 2011)

Conformity, then, can be understood as a practical social response: students may try to reduce visible differences so that interaction with age peers becomes easier. Fong et al., summarizing work grounded in Swiatek and related studies, describe coping strategies used to minimize differences with average peers and facilitate social interaction, including denying and hiding giftedness, discounting popularity, seeking conformity, helping others, and joining activities. (Fong et al., 2014) Aziz et al. make the same point in a more cautionary way, noting that some gifted students face conformity pressure and may hide their talents in order to be accepted and meet peer expectations. (Aziz et al., 2021)

An important nuance is that these choices are tied to self-concept as well as peer dynamics. Perceived social competence may be linked to whether students face or deny their giftedness in response to feeling different. (Casino-Garcia et al., 2021) So, in Swiatek's framework, denial, popularity-seeking, and conformity are not random traits; they are socially shaped ways of handling the tension between standing out for high ability and wanting everyday peer acceptance.

Evidence

(Korolov, 2024)

ASSERTIVENESS IN GIFTED PERSONAL RESOURCES SYSTEM IN DIFFICULT LIFE SITUATIONS

> *""In order to gain peer acceptance, gifted adolescents often deny their giftedness, value popularity over achievement, and conform to peer norms" (Swiatek, 1995)."*

(Pinxten et al., 2026)

Emotional and social well-being of gifted adolescents

> *"Popularity and peer acceptance by gifted students have been associated with denial of giftedness or conformity to peers (Cross et al., 1991, 2006; Swiatek, 1995; Swiatek and Dorr, 1998)."*

(Yun et al., 2011)

Mathematically Gifted Adolescents Have Deficiencies in Social Valuation and Mentalization

> *"These findings are consistent with previous studies of mathematically gifted adolescents that have described difficulties in social and emotional coping strategies (Swiatek, 1995). Specifically, a study using questionnaires found that highly gifted adolescents perceive themselves as less popular, having a greater internal locus of control, and having more social and emotional problems than average adolescents (Brody et al., 1986). In ratings of peer perceptions of athleticism, popularity and social standing, modestly gifted adolescents exceeded the highly gifted, indicating that giftedness may entail risks of developing problems in peer relations (Dauber et al., 1990)."*

(Fong et al., 2014)

Perfectionism and Chinese Gifted Learners

> *"Guided by previous investigations on the social coping strategies adopted by Western gifted learners (Colangelo et al., 1983)(Gross, 1989)Pfeiffer & Stocking, 2000;Piechowski, 1997;Swaitek, 1995), Chan (2003a(Chan, 2004)(Chan, 2005) found that Chinese gifted learners generally use coping strategies to minimize their differences with average peers and to facilitate social interaction with peers. To these ends, coping strategies that Chinese gifted learners typically apply include denying and hiding their giftedness, discounting popularity, attempting avoidance, seeking conformity, helping others, and involvement in activities."*

(Aziz et al., 2021)

Exploration of Challenges Among Gifted and Talented Children

> *"Some of them might faces conformity pressures. They might hide their talents in order to be accepted and conform to the peer expectation resulted on developing frustrations, anxiety and depression and resistance to authority (Wright-Scott, 2018)."*

(Casino-Garcia et al., 2021)

Emotional Intelligence Profiles and Self-Esteem/Self-Concept: An Analysis of Relationships in Gifted Students

> *"Perceived social competence, as well as other domains of self-concept, may be linked to the strategies students use to face or deny their giftedness, in regard to feeling different [28]."*

Measurement and structure of Swiatek's coping framework

Swiatek's coping framework was not just a loose list of behaviors; it was organized into a questionnaire meant to measure how gifted students handle the social side of being seen as gifted. In that measurement model, denial, popularity/ conformity, peer acceptance, and activity level appeared as distinct but related parts of social coping. (1 source)

Swiatek's 1995 framework was operationalized through the **Social Coping Questionnaire (SCQ)**, which was designed to assess the specific coping methods gifted students use in response to the social meaning of giftedness. In its original form, the SCQ included **35 items** focused on "beliefs and activities relating to various social aspects of intellectual giftedness," making the framework measurable rather than purely descriptive. A component analysis of SCQ scores identified **four main dimensions**: **Denial of Giftedness, Popularity/Conformity, Peer Acceptance, and Activity Level**. This structure helps clarify that the strategies discussed earlier are not all the same kind of response: some involve directly downplaying giftedness, some involve fitting in socially, some center on being accepted by peers, and some involve staying active in valued activities as a way of managing social life. (KONIK, 2023)

Evidence

(KONIK, 2023)

Turkish adaptation of Social Coping Questionnaire for gifted students

> *"Swiatek developed the Social Coping Questionnaire in 1995 to evaluate the particular coping mechanisms employed by gifted students.In its original form, the SCQ (Swiatek, 1995) had 35 questions "that address beliefs and activities relating to various social aspects of intellectual giftedness."A component analysis of the scores revealed four social coping mechanisms: Denial of Giftedness, Popularity/Conformity, Peer Acceptance, and Activity Level."*

Consequences and broader patterns of denying or hiding giftedness

Hiding or denying giftedness can help a student get through peer situations in the short term, but it can also come with real costs. Across later work, these costs include underachievement, "dumbing down," and a weaker or more conflicted sense of gifted identity. (3 sources)

A key broader pattern in the literature is that denying or hiding giftedness is often treated as a social survival move rather than simple modesty. Later summaries of this line of work say gifted students may hide their giftedness as a way to cope in social settings, especially when they are trying to fit in or avoid standing out. (Nor et al., 2024) This can take the form of "dumbing down" or blending in with non-gifted peers, which has been described as a coping strategy used to fit in. (Furner et al., 2011)

The problem is that this short-term social protection can have longer-term costs. Furner et al. warn that severe coping patterns can include trying to blend in, underachievement, and even more serious distress. (Furner et al., 2011) In other words, when students repeatedly mute visible ability for peer reasons, the issue is not only social presentation; it can also affect performance, engagement, and well-being.

A second broader consequence is identity loss or concealment. Recent work describes high-ability adolescents as sometimes "codeswitching" or facing a forced-choice dilemma between ability and belonging. In that process, they may hide their cognitive abilities to gain security and connection, but the result can be concealment, loss, or denial of a gifted identity. (Visser et al., 2025) This extends Swiatek's framework in an important way: denial of giftedness is not just a tactic for peer acceptance, but part of a wider pattern in which adolescents may feel they have to choose between being known as gifted and being socially safe.

Evidence

(Nor et al., 2024)

Seen and Heard: Combining In-Depth Interviewing With Social Messaging to Study the Lived Experiences of Gifted Youth in High Power Distance Cultures

> *"As a way to cope, they tend to hide their giftedness (Cross et al., 2009)(Rudasill et al., 2007)(Swiatek, 2002)"*

(Furner et al., 2011)

Counting on Frank : Using bibliotherapy in mathematics teaching to prevent de-geniusing

> *"Dumbing down can actually be thought of as a 'coping' strategy for these students in order to fit in (Cross, 1997)(L., 2021)"*

> *".Teachers need to teach their gifted students strategies so that they will not employ these severe patterns of coping behaviours that include trying to blend in with non-gifted students, under-achievement, and even suicidal behaviour (Cross, 1997)."*

(Visser et al., 2025)

Code-switching and the forced choice dilemma as obstacle in Identity Development of gifted adolescents.

> *"adolescents with high abilities often codeswitch or face a dilemma of forced choice as they seek security and connection in their social environment. These strategies lead them to hide their high cognitive abilities in an attempt to integrate into the sociocultural environment, which results in a loss, concealment or denial of their identity as gifted adolescents."*